Healthy Living as taught by the Ma'sumeen

(With Extracts from Rizalat Al Zhahabiyya)

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EXTRACTS FROM RISALATUZH ZHAHABIYYA
(The treatise of Gold)

INTRODUCTION

Mamoon Rashid had requested Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) to advise him, in the light of the knowledge of his forefathers (the Ahlul-Bayt), what to eat and drink, so as to support a healthy life and to get rid of diseases and infirmities. In response, Imam wrote him a long letter giving details of the rules for sound health, when and what to eat and drink. Mamoon was so impressed that he got the letter re-written in gold liquid, hence it is popularly known as "Risalatu-al-Zhahabiyya" (a letter as good and valuable as gold). And he gave instructions to preserve it in the royal treasures.

"Allah does not afflict anybody with a single ailment for which a corresponding cure is not available. Therefore, for every kind of disease, there is a medicine and cure".

THE HUMAN BODY

Human bodies are like a government. The soul is the ruling head; the brain, nerves and joints are agents; the heart is the seat of authority and the body is the territory.

The hands, feet, lips, tongue, eyes and ears are the servants; the stomach and intestines are the storehouse and the chest is the chamber of a door-keeper.

The hands carry out the orders bringing things near or throwing them far away, as directed. The feet move and transport the ruler whenever he wants to go.

The eyes make him see and take notice because the ruler is a recluse, for whom everything is in darkness unless the eyes throw light and makes the vision clear.

The ears are like an ever-alert body guard. They bring to one's notice what is agreeable to his temperament, or as ordered. So whenever he

wants to listen, he beats the drums (inside the ears) through which he hears what he wants and gives answers in response.

The tongue is the medium to express intention. Its movement depends upon co-operation of many other agents like breath, excretions of the stomach and the lips.

The lips have their faculty because of the tongue and together are correlated to each other when making speech. Expression of the tongue and speech cannot be clear and smoothly available unless it echoes through the sinuses in the nose.

The nose was designed to make spoken words or speech distinct and clear in a fashion similar to that created by a flute; i.e. being regular, measured and balanced. The nostrils not only act as the flute but also serve to use the sense of smell to inhale and exhale. Through the closure of the nostrils, the stink and stench disliked by him are stopped by the hand, by his orders.

THE SOUL

“For the ruler of the body (soul), reward and punishment have been ordained….

The punishment of the soul is sorrow. Its recompense is happiness.

The spleen is the root of sorrow. The kidneys and stomach membrane are the source of happiness.

Two veins from these organs travel up to the face and through this the effects of sorrow and happiness are clearly visible for all to see.

All such veins are the means of communication between the ruler and his governing agents.

When medicine enters the body, the agents carry it to the suffering centre.

STAGES OF LIFE

A human being in his lifetime passes through four stages (states of health, disposition and mind):
The **first** stage begins at 15 and lasts until 25. This is the prime time of youth, beauty, goodness, learning, understanding and cleverness which is dominated by the power of full blood flow.

The **second** stage begins at 25 and lasts until 35. The influence of yellow bile provides for an age full of strength, power and intellect, a climax which never comes back again.

The **third** stage begins at 35 and lasts until 60. The influence of black bile brings with it the age of wisdom, skills, intellect, judgement and management, foresight and faithful commitments.

The **fourth** stage begins at 60 and lasts until death. Growing old and weak every day, slumber takes over when it is time to be wide awake and sleeplessness gets on the nerves when it is time to rest and relax.

Loss of memory, fickle mindedness, hair loss, etc happens. This is because phlegm is in command.

NUTRITION

Whatever we eat and drink there is a connection with our anatomy and how we take them affects our entire health. Vitality of the spirit follows the disposition and constitution of the body which in turn depend upon, climatic conditions. They alter and adjust to the degree of change in the atmosphere of one's habitation.

The body reacts according to the weather. If the weather is mild, pleasant and moderate, it keeps the disposition and constitution of the body in balance.

Nature correctly sets the activity and behaviour of the body. Management, use of health and disposition are adjusted through natural activities (digestion, sleep, work etc). Your health, anger, mood and state of mind are clearly connected to four natural dispositions:

- Gall fluid *(black bile from the spleen*)
- Bile (*yellow fluid secreted by the liver*)
- Blood

- Phlegm (*thick yellowish substance formed in the throat*)

Each of the above indicates the four regions of the body – head, chest, ribs and lower abdomen.
Blood has influence over the head, ears, eyes, nostrils and mouth.
Phlegm rules on the chest.
Yellow bile takes over the ribs.
Gall fluid takes over the lower abdomen.

Remember that each human being has a different, natural, disposition according to his shape, form and nature; and accepts only that which agrees and adjusts. Therefore, eat and drink what is agreeable with your system. Overeating is not good for the body and neither should you eat more nor less that what you can. When your appetite desires a little more, stop eating immediately since regulating the digestive system keeps the mind alert, and trims the body into an agile and strong shape.

In **summer**, eat things which have a cooling effect in their ingredients. In **winter**, select food that

excites sensation of warmth. In temperate season, use ingredients mixed in due proportion, neither hot nor cold.

At meal time, first eat those foods which are easily digestible. However, what is easily digestible depends upon the habits, age and fitness, desire of the eater and also on the climate.

To regulate one's systems, The Prophet (pbuh), advised Imam Ali (pbuh), to have three meals in 48 hours. On the first day, eat only once at 11 o'clock followed by two meals the next day…..

Sleep affects the brain. It keeps the body firm, well ordered and in the right measure. When you go to sleep, lie down on the right side first then turn to the left. During sleep, the body's position may change from left to right, and vice versa, but at the time of waking up you must be lying on the right side.

Train your mind to have a restful sleep and make a habit of getting up 2 hours before the day

begins. Once woken, begin to freshen up yourself by brushing your teeth. The best toothbrush is that of miswaak. It cleans and disinfects the teeth, produces fresh breath, firms the gums and prevents tooth decay. While brushing your teeth do not be too firm and do not slow down, but be moderate. Being too firm will thin out the brush and weakening its 'teeth' and loosening it from the roots.

To protect the teeth, use a tooth powder made of the following ingredients.

- Ayyil Muharaqaa -Stag horn-fern
- Kizmaazaj – Tamarisk
- Saa'daan – Wart weed
- Ward – Red Roses
- Sunbul Tayyib – Spikenard
- H'abbul Athal – Seeds of tamarisk

Measure the above equally adding ¼ rock salt and grind them to fine powder. This will reduce the risk of decay and deterioration in the teeth and gums. To increase the whiteness on your teeth use rock salt powder with the foam of sea water.

MONTH BY MONTH FOOD GUIDE

JANUARY

To avoid thickening of the phlegm in the throat, drink lukewarm water daily in the morning. Try and eat lots of green vegetables, mints, soybeans etc, but do not eat fish or drink milk in this month. This is a good month to begin massaging the body once more.

FEBRUARY

Try and eat fowl, birds, garlic and dry fruits. Avoid too much sugar. It is recommended to do body building exercises.

MARCH

All its days are considered to be refreshing and mild. The ground is soft and preparing for the birth of new plants. As far as the human body is concerned, the growth of phlegm (thick yellowish substance formed in the throat) is less and blood circulation is increased. In this month, one should eat tender, easily digestive food. Onions, garlic and food containing sour ingredients should be

avoided. Also this is the best time to purify the body and soul.

APRIL

The weather during this month is very soothing and stimulating, with the wind blowing from East to West. The circulation of blood, in the body, stirs up the excitement. This month is known as a barbecue season and one should try to add vinegar to food.

MAY

The air is generally fresh and cool in this, the last month of spring. Avoid eating those meats which are hard to digest e.g. beef and also avoid eating foods rich in salt. Exercise is not suitable as your stomach is empty. It is also advisable to have a bath in the early hours of the day.

JUNE

The power of the blood looses its force and phlegm takes over in the body. Therefore, avoid excessive physical exercise and oily foods. Keep away from strong fragrances, e.g. musk and amber. Try and eat fresh vegetables (cabbage,

lettuce, cucumber, etc) and juicy fruits. For strength, eat goat-meat, fowl, partridge, quail, fresh fish and milk.

JULY

It is the warmest month of the year. It is advisable to drink water in the morning. Try and eat fresh food containing cool ingredients and that which is easily digestible. Indulge yourself with the fragrances produced by fresh flowers.

AUGUST

In this month, the wind is polluted giving rise to a season of cold and cough. Sometimes the breeze from the north reduces the dryness in the air. Try and eat dairy products and minimise exercise. Only mild fragrances should be used during this month.

SEPTEMBER

Constipation is common so avoid eating oily foods. Increase the ratio of sugar in your food but avoid watermelons and cucumbers. Massage of the body during this month is not advisable.

OCTOBER

Eat plenty of fruits after a spicy and greasy meal. It is highly recommended to exercise the body.

NOVEMBER

This is the end of autumn and the beginning of winter. Every morning drink one mouthful of lukewarm water before eating anything. Try and reduce the use of oils and steam in the bath. Mint is also not advisable.

DECEMBER

Winter is at its peak. Follow the instructions given for the month of November and remember that it is not advisable to eat food containing cool ingredients, but food with high calories. Where possible, avoid having your hair cut.

SHARABUS SALEHEEN AL-RAZAWI

THE WHOLESOME SYRUP

Imam Ridha (pbuh) recommended the drinking of pure and seasoned syrup after meals, to be made according to the following instructions:

Wash and clean 10 Rat'al* of high quality black raisin (without seeds/pips) and place them in 3 inches of deep clean water, preferably rain water, or water taken from a stream flowing eastward – because, unlike other forms of water, it is usually clear and soft, easily absorbing heat or cold.

Keep it in the water for either three days during winter, or one day in the summer. Then boil in a clean cooking vessel until the raisin puffs out and becomes unstuck (but do not break them up). After cooling the raisins, squeeze them and draw out the juice.

Put the juice in the pot, measure it and cook on a slow fire till two thirds evaporates. Add one Rat'al pure honey. To this new liquid, add the following herbs thoroughly ground, with impurities

removed - each one separately weighed and packed in fine thin cloth packets, tightly tied and closed in one cotton bag.

- Ginger 1 *dirham
- Cloves ½ dirham
- Cinnamon ½ dirham
- Saffron 1 dirham
- Spikenard ½ dirham
- Wild chicory dirham
- Mastic ½ dirham

Measure the liquid, place in a pan and boil. While heating, keep pressing the cotton bag to squeeze out the juice from the herbs until the liquid evaporates to the level of the honey. Cool the vessel and put the juice into a glass or porcelain jar. To allow the ingredients to set, blend together (shake well). Leave this jar for a period of three months, after which time the juice can be used as drinking syrup.
After meals, take 31 grams of liquid from the jar and 62 grams of pure water and drink this syrup. It will keep you safe for 24 hours, from the following ailments:

Chronic indigestion, Arthritis, Flatulence, Ailments, pains and aches of the brain, stomach, muscles, nerves, liver, spleen, intestines and bowels. Your body will stay healthy and you will have lots of energy.

***Dirham – 3.2 gms**

***Ratal – 2.88 kgs**

SAMPLE PROPHETIC PRESCRIPTIONS

FEVER

"If a person has fever sprinkle cold wate over him for water extinguishes the temperature of the body of the feverish person." Imam Ali (pbuh)

INDIGESTION & COLIC

"Eat the yellow part of the egg (i.e. yolk) so that your indigestion is cured." Imam Ridha (pbuh)
"Eating dates saves one from colic."

TUBERCULOSIS

"Sweet basil opens internal joints and frees them from clogging and increases appetite and cures tuberculosis." Imam Kadhim (pbuh)
"For the person affected with tuberculosis nothing is better than rice-bread." Imam Ridha (pbuh)

PILES

"Combine aniseed or bishop's weed with walnuts to cure piles, remove wind from the body, clear the complexion, improve the digestive system and warm the kidneys." Imam Sadiq (pbuh)

“Consume figs to cure piles” Prophet (pbuh)

HEADACHES

Splash the head with seven handfuls of warm water and before each splashing say ‘Bismillah’. Imam Ridha (pbuh)

EYE PAIN

Muffazzal ibn Umar states that he complained of pain in the eyes before Imam Sadiq (pbuh). Imam told him that when he washes his hands after a meal, he should keep the wet hands on his eye brows and eye-lids and recite the following dua three times:

‘Wal hamdu lil lahil muhsinil mujmilil mum’imil mutafazzil.

People suffering form eye sores should avoid eating fish.

When a man complained to The Prophet (pbuh) about pain in his eyes; he was told “Gaze upon the Qur’an”.

IMPROVING MEMORY

Mix honey, celery, common rue, saffron, sage in equal quantity and eat 10 grams every day whilst

reciting Ayatul Kursi increases the memory of a person.

ALL AILMENTS

Chicory or endive cures remove every kind of pain existing in the body. Grinding and then mixing it with the oil of violet flower and applying it on the head, is most effective for curing fever and headaches.

The Prophet (pbuh) recommends this dua after Fajr Salaa for even the most incurable disease. Recite it 40 times and rub hands over the area.

Bismillahir Rahmanir Rahim

Alhamdu lillahi Rabbil ‘alameen
Hasbunallahu wa ni'mal wakeel
tabarakallahu ahsanal khaliqeen
wa la hawla wa la quwwata illa billahil 'Aliyyil 'Azheem

“Recite Suratul Fatiha 7x or 70x pulling one’s shirt over ones head to recover from any illness” Imam Hasan Askery (pbuh).

The Prophet (pbuh) said, “Jibraail has taught me a cure which makes one needless of all medicines. Collect rain water before it falls on the ground in a clean vessel and recite on it Suratul Fatiha, Suratul Ikhlas, Suratul Falaq and Suratun Naas seventy times each, then drink it in the morning and at night. By Allah, who appointed me in truth, He will remove pain from his body, bones, marrow and vessels.”

STAMMERING IN CHILDREN

Recite Surah Jumua’ on water and make them drink.

FOR ALL STOMACH AILMENTS

The Prophet (pbuh) has said:
In order to prevent stomach ailments, recite Suratut Teen on the food and then eat, it is so mujarrab that even if someone has mixed poison in food it will not effect.

FOR A PEACEFUL SLEEP

One teaspoon of honey at night.

ADVICE AND BENEFITS OF VARIOUS FOODS

APPLE
Good to eat all year round.

BARLEY
Eating barley is good for lung disease, diarrhoea and a cure for pains and body aches.

BEETROOT
Cure for baldness. Its roots are a cure for insomnia.

BLACK CARAWAY SEEDS
“Black seeds are a cure for all pain except the disease of death. I recommend you to eat black-seeds along with honey.” Imam Kadhim (pbuh).

CHEESE
Imam Muhammad Baqir (pbuh) says to eat cheese at night – not during the day – good if you want sons.

CHICKEN
Adbul A'laa ate at the Imam's house – the chicken was stuffed with dates & oil.

CUCUMBER
God has invested cures for all diseases in cucumbers.

DATES
Imam Ja'fer As-Sadiq (pbuh) was asked about Allah's saying "And let him see what food is purest there and bring you a provision form it." 18:19
Imam (pbuh) replied: "The date is the purest food".
Ref. Furu Al kafi No. l6 page 345
"Eating dates saves a human being from colic."

EGGS
A man complained to the Imam Ridha pbuh Ithat they have difficulty in conceiving - The Imam suggested that he eats egg & onion and does Istighfaar.

FIGS

Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) says:

- Strengthens the bones
- Improves hair growth
- Cures colic
- Cures pains especially joint pains
- Increases sexuality
- Cures piles

FISH

Water must be drunk after eating fish and if fish is consumed at night, honey or dates or a sweet dish should be eaten after it.

Eating too much fish helps reduce weight.

GUAVA

It cleanses the stomach, gives strength and is best to eat after meals.

HONEY

“Honey is a cure for all diseases.” Imam Ali (pbuh).

LENTILS

Softens the heart.

LETTUCE
Cleanses one's blood.

MEAT
Imam Sadiq (pbuh) said, "Eat meat on one day, the next day milk and something else on the third day." We have also been advised to abstain from eating freshly slaughtered meat or half cooked meat.
Imam Muhammad Baqir (pbuh) narrates that the Bani Israil complained of dandruff to Prophet Musa (pbuh) and they were ordered to eat beef with beetroot.
Eating meat cooked in milk is a diet of the Prophets.

MELON/ WATER MELON
The Prophet (pbuh) said: "None of your women who are pregnant and eat of water melon will fail to produce offspring who are good in countenance and good in character.
Eating water melon cleanses the stomach before meals eliminating diseases.

ONION

Eat the onion of any city you visit and it protects you from diseases. Imam Sadiq (pbuh) says eating onions cleanses teeth and strengthens the roots, cures phlegm, lessons fatigue & laziness, increases fertility, cures fever and beautifies complexions.

PLUMS

Imam Musa Kadhim (pbuh) said to Ziyad Kundi that plums cure nausea and fever. Dried plums are good to balance the temperature of the blood and cures physical aches.

POMEGRANATE

It helps digestion and if eaten first thing in the morning on Friday it provides enlightenment. Water after eating pomegranates should be avoided.

PUMPKIN

Increases memory & wisdom.

QUINCE

Imam Ali (pbuh) says that quince:

- Strengthens a weak heart
- Helps to increase weight
- Cleanses the stomach
- Increases reason
- Makes a person courageous
- Improves complexion
- Good looking children if eaten during pregnancy.

RADISH

Good for stomach ailments.

RAISINS

Imam Ali (pbuh) said: “eating 21 pieces of raisins (kishmish) in breakfast safeguards from all diseases except the death causing sickness.”

RICE

Cures diarrhoea. For stomach aches, Imam Sadiq (pbuh) advises to wash and dry rice and then powder it and consume a tablespoon every morning.

TURNIP

Reduces leprosy & baldness.

VINEGAR AND OLIVE OIL

Consuming vinegar and olive oil: Imam Ali (pbuh) has said: “Any family which eats Roghan-e-Zaytun (olive oil) and sirka (vinegar) regularly will not be afflicted with poverty (i.e. they will not fall sick).” He has also said that vinegar protects the heart.

Prophet Muhammad (pbuh) has said: “Use olive oil and anoint yourself with it, because it is ‘from a blessed tree’” (24:35) Other benefits include:

- It keeps the hair shiny and prevents dandruff.
- Used as a balm, it fortifies and moisturises the skin, combating dry skin and softening it. It also combats against acne.
- Massaged onto the body, if fortifies the limbs, combats against inflammation, and soothes away aches and pains from tired muscles and so on.
- Help against wrinkles and delaying the effects of old age.

- Help combat against strokes, heart-disease, high blood pressure and diabetes.
- It aids digestion and strengthens the bowels, as well as the stomach.
- Soothes pain
- Strengthens the body's immune system
- Drunk, the tea from Olive leaves help against high blood pressure.
- General consumption of Olives, due to their high anti-Oxidant properties, help to combat against diseases such as cancer (studies in particular show Breast cancer), asthma, arthritis, osteoporosis, and others.

WALNUTS

Imam Ali (pbuh) says that eating these during the summer causes acne & boils yet they are good to eat in the winter – it keeps the body warm. It is good to eat with cheese.

WATER

Imam Sadiq (pbuh) says, cold water lessens temperature, cures vomiting, digests food, and is

an antidote for heat. He also stated that boiled water is good for all types of pain and is not harmful in any way.

It has been related that the water of the well of Zamzam, rain water and the water of the river Euphrates, carry many benefits and excellence.

Imam Ali (pbuh) has said that drinking water (especially rain water) at night, while you are in a sitting position, and during the day, while you are standing, purifies the body and cures all pains and diseases.

Say ‘Bismillah (in the name of Allah) when you are going to drink something and Alhamdu-lillah (Praise be to Allah) when you have finished drinking; and remember Imam Hussein, his family and companions (peace be upon them)

- Drink water slowly and do not fill your mouth with it
- Do not gulp water in one single gulp; instead drink it in at least three gulps.

MANNERS OF EATING AND DRINKING

The son of Adam has but to have a meal to keep his spine upright. So, when you eat, let one-third of your stomach be for food, one third for drink, and one third for breathing.

- "The life of a person who performs wudhu before taking his meal is prolonged and his body becomes secure against disease".
- Abstain from hot food: Imam Ali (pbuh) said, 'hot food was brought for The Prophet (pbuh); he said – keep it aside till it cools, Allah has not given us fire as food and blessing lies in cold food."
- Do not eat anything when your stomach is full
- Not to eat between breakfast and dinner is recommended
- Not to eat breakfast and dinner is harmful for one's health
- Washing one's hands and mouth before and after meals is the sunna of the Prophet (pbuh)

- When food is laid on the dining table you should say, Bismillah (In the name of Allah) and should commence and finish your meals with tasting salt.
- You should sit at the dining table respectfully, like slaves, as a mark of humility before your Rabb.
- It is makruh to eat alone
- Eating whilst sitting on the ground is mustahab.
- Have vegetables and vinegar on your dining table.
- Do not eat food while it is too hot.
- Do not give up eating barley bread
- Take small morsels and chew them well.
- Have a good meal while you are with a brother in faith and refrain from the things which he does not like
- Eat that which falls on the dining table.
- Pick your teeth after having your meal. After picking your teeth rinse your mouth three times
- “Never eat the particle of food which comes out from between the teeth by

means of a toothpick because they are the cause of internal ulcers.”

- It is recommended that one should do dua for the one who feeds him.
- When The Prophet (pbuh) used to have guests, he used to start first and end last, so that no guest may remain hungry.

MISCELLANEOUS

Feeding people is recommended on 5 occasions:

1. Marriage
2. Aqiqa
3. Circumcision of one's son
4. Purchasing a house.
5. Returning home from travel

One of the rights of the guest is that you should provide him with a toothpick and you should accompany them up to the door of your house when they leave. Do not go to take meals at the house of another person unless you are invited by him. Do not give orders to the master of the house. Sit where he asks you to sit. If you are invited to a meal you should accept the invitation.

Advice to travellers: Imam Sadiq (pbuh) said, "When you arrive at a place eat the onion of that place, it protects you from the prevalent epidemic (of disease in that community)."

THE ISLAMIC METHOD, AND BIOLOGICAL APPLICATIONS, OF SLAUGHTERING ANIMALS

"You are forbidden (to eat) that which dies of itself, blood, and the flesh of pigs and also any flesh dedicated to any other that Allah. You are forbidden the flesh of strangled animals and of those killed by a fall or mangled by beast of prey, unless you find it still alive and slaughter it; also of animal sacrificed on stones (to idols). 5:30

A deep study reveals that the Islamic method of animal slaughter has special biological significance to render many benefits. Essentially there are four essential conditions laid down by shariah for animal slaughtering:

1. The person who slaughters the animal must be a Muslim
2. The name of Allah must be pronounced before incision and made, facing the animal in the direction of the Holy Ka'ba
3. The instrument being used for slaughtering should be extremely sharp

4. The incision should be made in the neck just below the glottis, cutting the throat and oesophagus, the jugular vein and the carotid artery without cutting the spinal cord.

Apart from these four conditions, the person slaughtering the animal must bear in mind that he should not interfere with the carcass before convulsions have completely ceased and the animal is pronounced biologically dead. Skinning or dismembering the animal just after the slaughtering (while breathing has not yet ceased) is not recommended in Islam.

In Islamic slaughtering, the killing by shock approach is refrained from. It is for this reason the Sharia has prescribed the following precautions to be maintained during the slaughtering process.

- The knife must not be sharpened in front of the animal
- The animals should not be slaughtered in front of each other

- The animals should be given water to drink before being slaughtered
- The animal should be laid on its side, soothed and should be stroked gently on its back

All these conditions help to reduce the fear of an animal prior to being slaughtered.
The prescribed method of Islamic slaughtering has many benefits. It saves the animal from the pain that can occur in other slaughtering methods due to muscle contractions and suspension of respiratory and other organic functions. In the prescribed method of incision, the animal's major blood vessel in the neck is abruptly cut off thereby producing an immediate stunning effect. This causes a sudden massive haemorrhage of blood which immediately cuts the supply of blood to the brain, thereby rendering the animal unconscious.

The Islamic way of slaughtering allows the maximum benefit from the body's natural mechanism. By cutting the major blood vessel without cutting the spinal cord, the body's own mechanism is used to drain the carcass of blood –

the important feature of Islamic slaughtering is to cut the blood supply to the brain without interfering with the communication links between the brain and the heart.

Apart from this there is a great medicinal significance of Halaal meat, identified by medical researchers. We know that blood performs many important functions in the body; it carries essential nutrients during its round the clock circulation to all tissue cells and carries away waste products left after the useful consumption of nutrient constituents. During its circulation in the body, blood also goes to the kidneys (the processing plants) which purify it for further work.

Two researchers, Gucel and Erbil, narrate that blood that carries nutrients also nourishes organisms which are responsible for disease. These organisms do not show any clinical symptoms in a healthy living body. But as soon as they are separated from the body, these diseases carrying organism become extremely harmful. It is for this reason that the consumption of blood is forbidden in Islam.

Blood in a carcass is the principle breeding place of all kinds of bacteria. If the carcass has not been adequately drained off, it putrefies the meat thereby making it dangerous for health. The convulsions of a slaughtering animal are therefore the most rapid and efficient method of making the carcass free of disease–carrying blood.

BLESSINGS BEFORE & AFTER A MEAL

BEFORE A MEAL

بِسْمِ اللهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيْمِ

In the name of God, the most Kind, the most Merciful

بِسْمِ الله وَبَرَكَةِ الله

In the name of God and with the blessings of God I begin to eat…

AFTER A MEAL

بِسْمِ اللهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيْمِ

In the name of God, the most Kind, the most Merciful

اَلْحَمْدُ للهِ الَّذِيْ اَطْعَمَنَا،

Praise be to God who fed us

وَسَقَانَا، وَكَفَانَا، وَاَيَّدَنَا،

Quenched us, sufficed us, supported us,

وَآوَانَا، وَاَنْعَمَ عَلَيْنَا، وَاَفْضَلَ.

Sheltered us, favoured us and bestowed benefits on us.

MONTH BY MONTH FOOD TABLE

Imam Ali Ridha (pbuh) recommended the following guidelines:

Month	Type of food
January	• Drink lukewarm water daily in the morning. • Eat green vegetable, mints etc • Do not eat fish or drink milk
February	• Eat fowls, birds, garlic and dry fruits • Use less sugar
March	• Eat tender, digestible food • Take meat and half boiled eggs • Avoid onions, garlic and food containing sour ingredients

Month	Type of food
April	• Barbeques, fries, fish and fowl along with vinegars • Do not drink water in the morning when the stomach is empty
May	• Do not eat meat that is hard to digest (jaw – meat, tongue, beef) and salty foods • Do not exert your body physically if your stomach is empty
June	• Eat fresh vegetables, • cucumber, cabbage, lettuce and as many leaf vegetable and juicy fruits as possible • Tender goat meat, fowl, partridge, quail, fresh fish and milk are good for building strength

Month	Type of food
July	• Eat fresh tender food containing cooling ingredients • Eat foods which are mild, juicy and easily digestible
August	• Take yoghurt, curd and similar milk products
September	• Increase sugar in food • Eat tender meat • Beef, and spicy rice cooked in oils or fat are harmful • Do not eat watermelons and cucumbers
October	• Eat spicy and greasy food, pomegranates (sweet or sour), but eat fruits after the meals. • Drink less water • Avoid oral medication

Month	Type of food
November	• Every morning, drink one mouthful of lukewarm water before eating • Avoid mints • Do not drink water after sunset
December	• Follow instructions for November • Eat high caloric food. • Do not eat food containing cooling ingredients

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